A poll conducted in December 2015 found that 77 per cent of Jewish Israelis felt unsafe, and that nearly half were reluctant to attend public Hanukkah celebrations.[1] After an attack in a supermarket, one of Israel's largest grocery chains pulled the knives and scissors from its aisles—even the pizza cutters, just to be safe. Gun stores, on the other hand, did a brisk business. The number of new applications for firearms permits soared.

In most countries, wars and acts of terrorism bring a "rally-around-the-flag" effect—as in the United States after 9/11, or France after the *Charlie Hebdo* massacre. Historically, Israel was no different; indeed, it had pulled together as recently as 2014, when the army had gone to war against Hamas and other militant groups in Gaza. Months later, a prominent leader of the settler movement reminisced almost nostalgically about the "sense of togetherness" he felt during the war. He compared the atmosphere to that during the 1973 Yom Kippur War, a conflict that threatened the very existence of the state.

Yet months of daily attacks produced no such unity in 2015. Outside Jerusalem, where the worst violence occurred, religious settlers held a protest in November—not because of the stabbings, but because of the Supreme Court's order to demolish the synagogue they had built illegally on private Palestinian land. They stockpiled explosives and warned that, "There will be a struggle here, and there are gas cylinders, and everything is permissible." Other hardliners chose a football match around the twentieth anniversary of Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin's death to chant the name of his assassin "Yigal" [Amir], as if they were celebrating him. In a further manifestation of the surging right, in October Amir's brother Hagai was arrested for inciting violence against the sitting president, Reuven Rivlin, on Facebook. Though Rivlin is a conservative opponent of the two-state solution, he has nonetheless earned the enmity of the Israeli right for urging coexistence between Jews and Arabs.

The reaction of the political establishment was underwhelming. The Labor Party, that scion of Israel's old secular, Zionist majority, briefly took notice of all this, then went back to haggling over a nominee to head the Jewish National Fund, a quasi-governmental body that develops land and plants trees. The country's Arab minority was beset by infighting, with the head of its parliamentary bloc and the mayor of its largest city bickering on live television about the economic danger that daily knifings posed to hummus restaurants and pastry shops in Nazareth.